

ARCHITECTURES OF INTERACTIVITY: MOVEMENT, SYSTEMS, AND THE BLACK BOX

by Polina Rud



1. FROM OBJECT TO FIELD: THE EMERGENCE OF ACTIVATION

- Why activate the viewer?
- What changes when perception becomes action?
- Who gains power when the spectator becomes a participant?
- Is participation the same as freedom?
- What kind of subject is being trained through interaction?

2. CYBERNETICS FEEDBACK AND THE BLACK BOX

- The invention of feedback
- Distributed control and homeostasis
- Systems that respond and adapt
- Communication as regulation
- Participation inside coded limits
- Adaptive machines and behavioral design
- The emergence of the black box

When you want to communicate an idea through your artwork, where does that communication actually happen?

Does it emerge mainly through what you say about the work (the concept, the text, the narrative, the images) or does it already exist within the form itself?

If everything else were removed and only the form remained (the material, structure, movement, scale, balance, rhythm), what would your work communicate?

And if you had to express that communication through one single word conveyed only by form, what would it be?

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Would you like to ask your viewer something about your artwork? What would that be?

Is there a situation in your practice where you could creatively use questionnaires as part of the work?

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Art shifts from static object to dynamic field. The artwork is no longer something to look at — it becomes something that unfolds through presence, movement, and time.
- The spectator moves from external observer to active component within the work. Change your position, your gesture, your attention — and the work changes.
- Interactivity emerges as a democratic gesture: activation replaces passivity, embodiment replaces distance, and art becomes a training ground for agency.
- By the late 1960s, participation is no longer only experienced — it is analyzed. The viewer's response becomes feedback, and feedback becomes data.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Cybernetics transforms interactivity from visible movement into invisible processing. The artwork no longer simply reacts, it adapts. Interactivity becomes a loop rather than a trigger.
- Every response is already a correction. The spectator appears to participate freely, but participation unfolds within an architecture designed to normalize behavior.
- Cybernetic artworks grant activity while defining its limits. The viewer acts and adapts, yet the range of responses is pre-coded. Freedom exists within rules; interactivity becomes the design of behavior.
- As systems grow more complex, their logic becomes opaque. We see input and output, but not the process in between. The viewer no longer stands before the work, but inside its feedback loop. Interactivity becomes procedural and increasingly invisible.